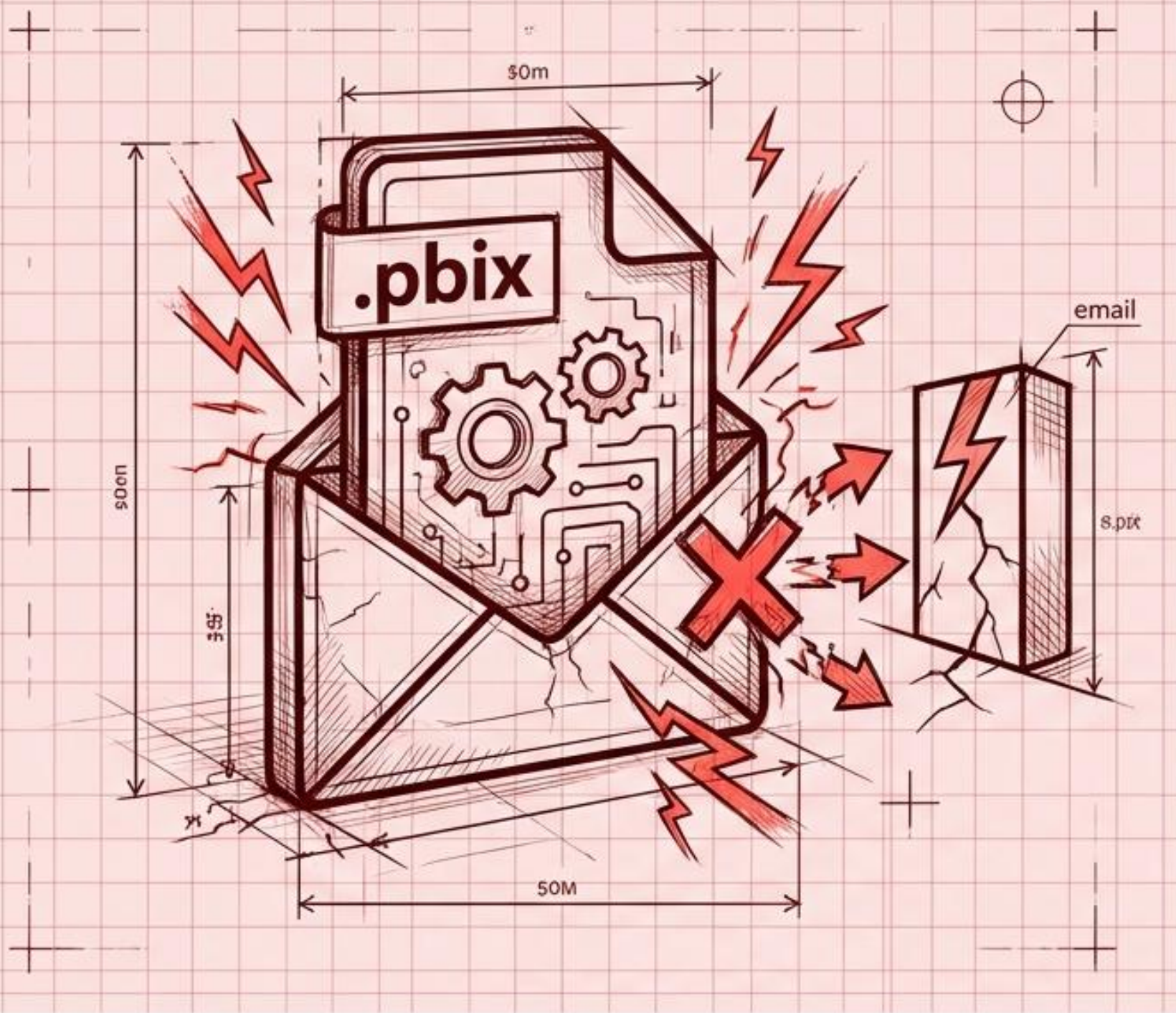




Power BI: Workspaces Management

Architecting Distribution, Collaboration, and Governance in the Power BI Service

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The Bottleneck of Local Files

Emailing .pbix (Power BI Desktop) files is an unsustainable distribution method. Files grow excessively large, face email server blocks, and lose access to dynamic Service-only features.



The Cloud Architecture Solution

The Power BI Service provides a centralized, secure environment for publishing, scheduling automated data refreshes, and managing team-wide collaboration.

Phase 1: Unique Identification



Save the .pbix report with a distinct, final name.

Phase 2: Authentication



Sign into the Power BI Service directly from the Desktop ribbon using Office 365 credentials.

Phase 3: Destination Targeting



Navigate to Home > Publish and select the appropriate target workspace.

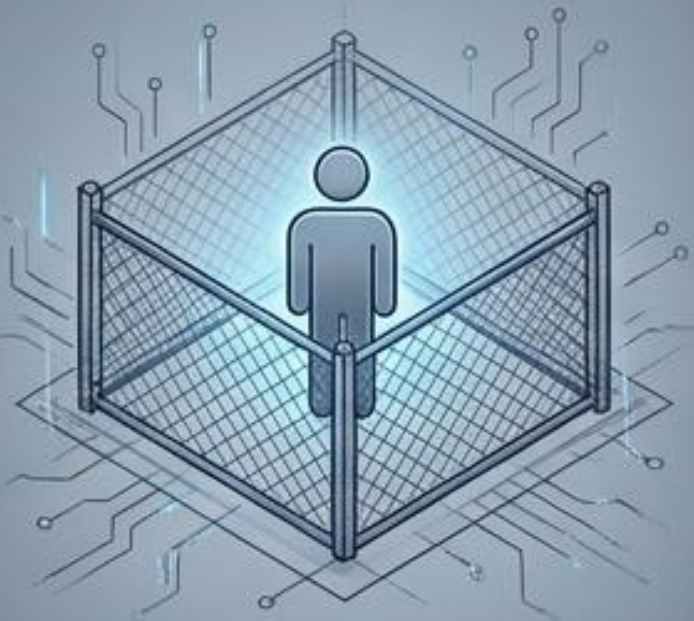
Phase 4: Launch & Verification



Upon successful publish, use the direct system link to immediately open and verify the report in the Service.

Workspace Environment Matrix

My Workspace (The Sandbox)



Purpose: Personal experimentation and testing.

- **Purpose:** Personal experimentation and testing.
- **Licensing:** Usable without a paid Power BI Pro license.
- **Limitations:** Manual data refreshes only. Not designed for sustainable organizational sharing.

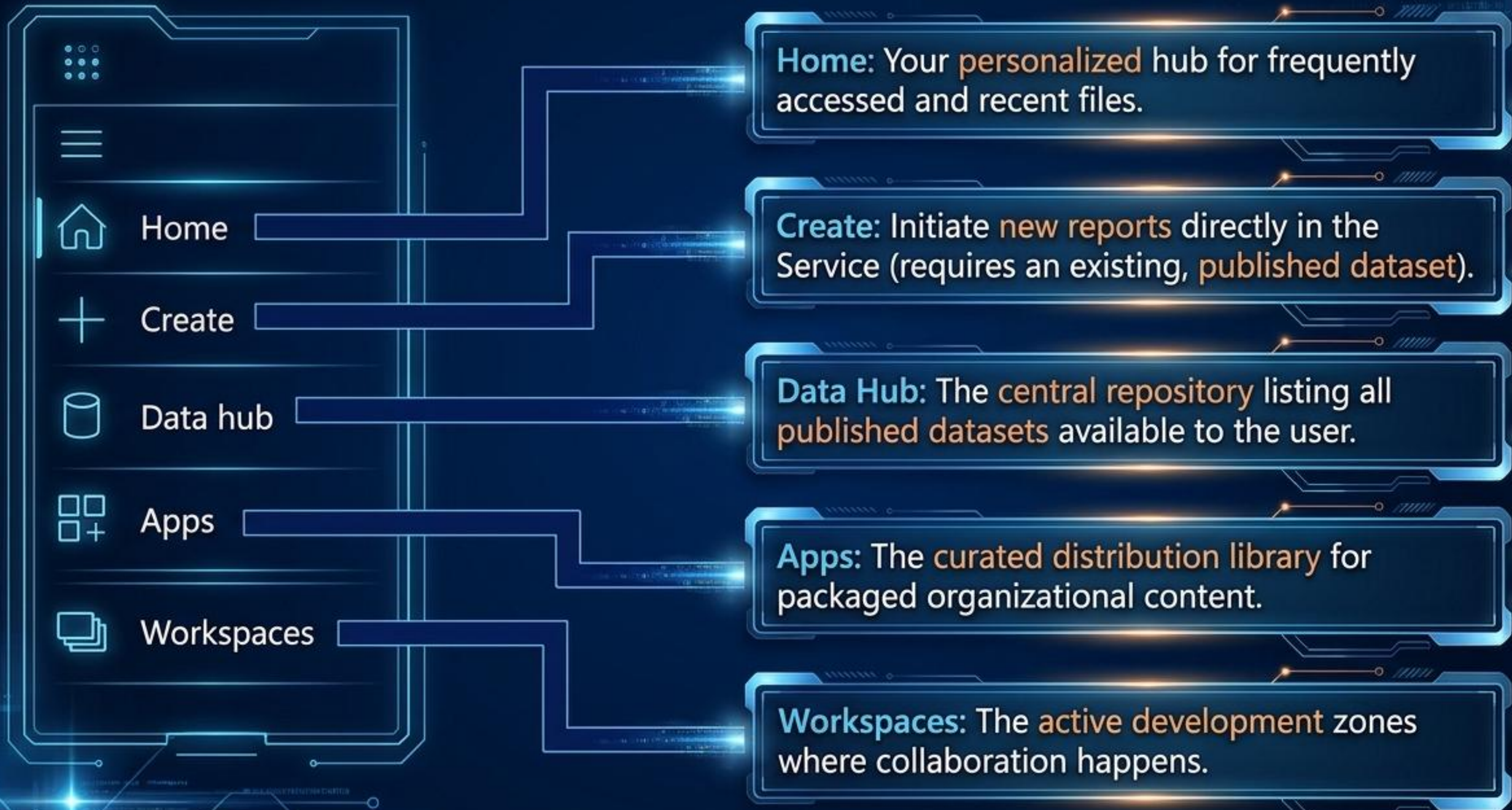
Workspaces (The Collaborative Hub)



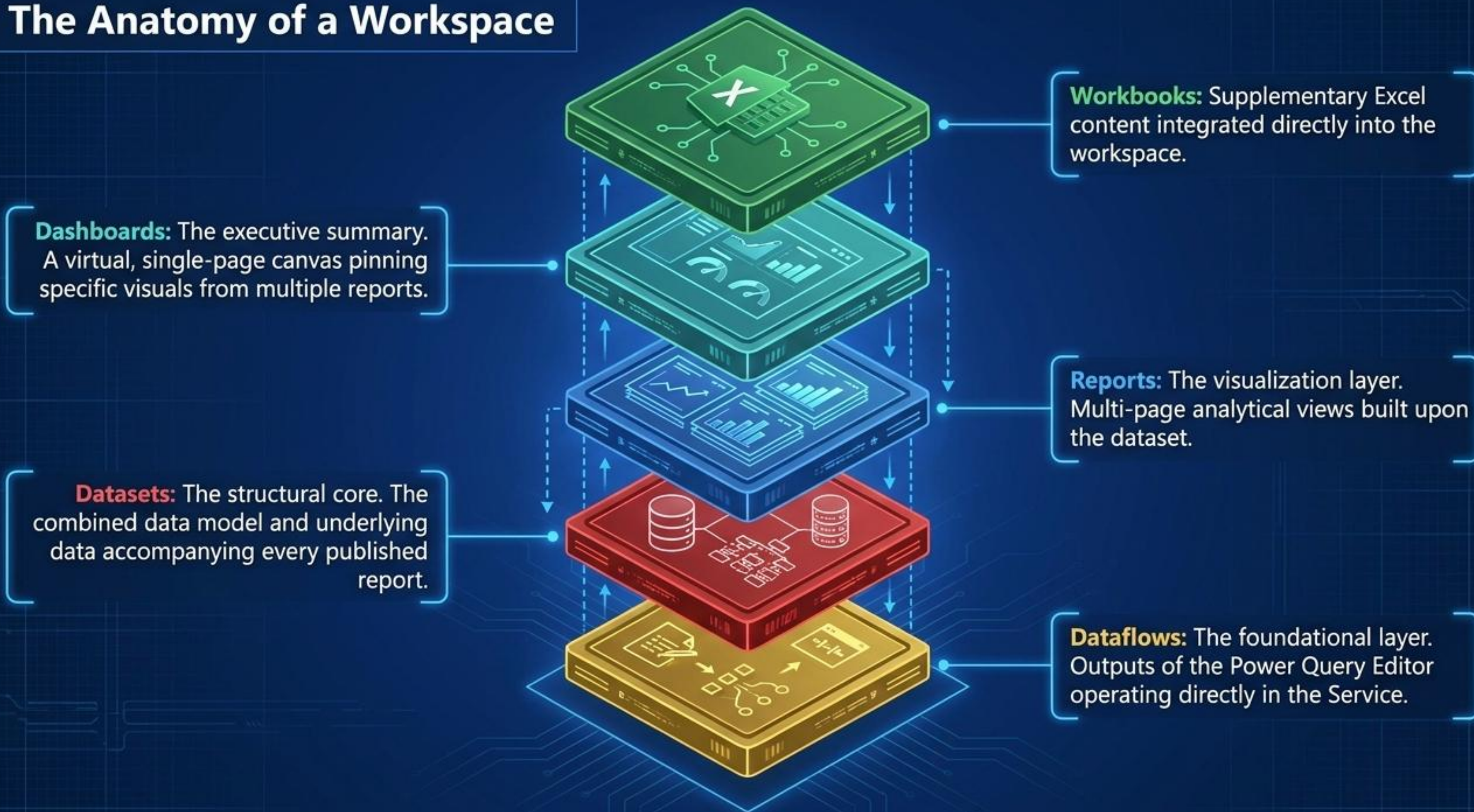
Capabilities: Requires appropriate Pro or Premium licensing.

- **Purpose:** Production-level collaboration and reporting.
- **Licensing:** Requires appropriate Pro or Premium licensing.
- **Capabilities:** Enables team editing, App distribution, automated schedules, and strict governance.

Architectural Map of the Service



The Anatomy of a Workspace



Governance Through Access Roles

	Viewer	Contributor	Member	Admin
View Content	✓	✓	✓	✓
Add / Edit / Delete Content		✓	✓	✓
Update Workspace App		✓*	✓	✓
Add Users			✓	✓
Delete Workspace				✓

Viewer Profile

Can only view content. No other rights.

Admin Profile

Possesses all Member rights, **PLUS** the ultimate authority to delete the entire workspace. (Best practice: minimum of two Admins).

Architecting a New Workspace

Strategic Description

Embed the workspace's purpose, target audience, and governance statement directly into the description field.

Dedicated OneDrive

Linking a workspace to a specific OneDrive allows for automated hourly refreshes of supporting Excel dataset files.

Naming Convention

Adhere to strict organizational naming rules to prevent duplicative or ambiguous workspaces.

Contact Ownership

Replace default IT Admins with actual Business Owners to route inquiries correctly.

Upgrading to Premium Capacity



The Premium Diamond:
Organizations can purchase dedicated server capacity to house specific workspaces, denoted by the diamond icon.

Massive Data Scale

Supports datasets expanding far beyond the standard 10 GB limit.

High-Frequency Refresh

Allows up to 48 automated data refreshes per day.

Paginated Reports

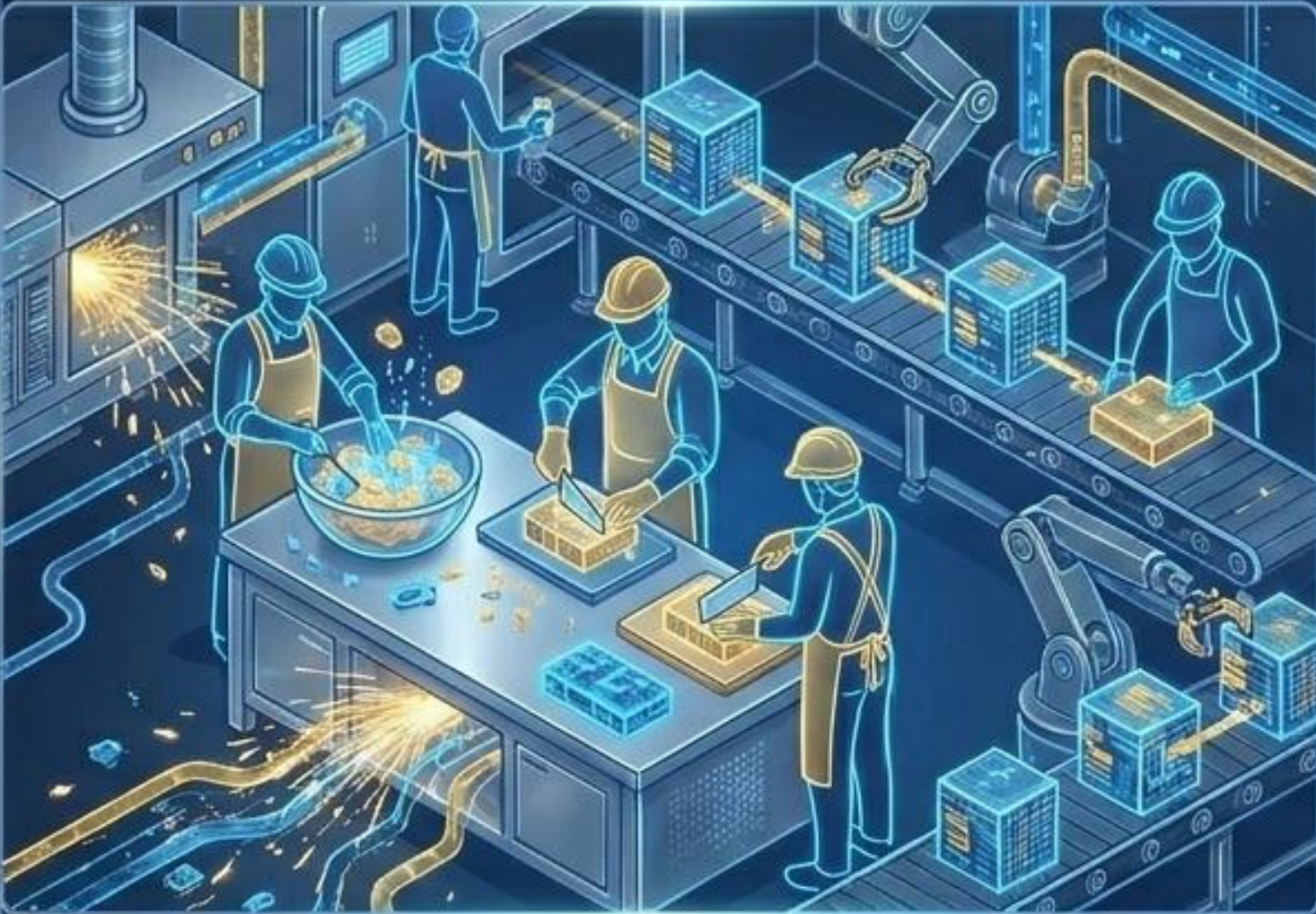
Unlocks pixel-perfect, highly formatted reporting formats.

Free-Tier Consumption

Viewers do not require a paid Pro license to consume content housed in Premium workspaces.

The Synthesis: Workspace vs. App

The Workspace (The Kitchen)



The messy, collaborative backend. This is where Admins, Members, and Contributors actively edit reports, transform data, and overwrite files.

The App (The Dining Room)



The curated, read-only frontend distribution vehicle. Functions like a published magazine or newsletter. Viewers are protected from seeing ongoing, incomplete edits happening in the workspace.

The Protective Buffer

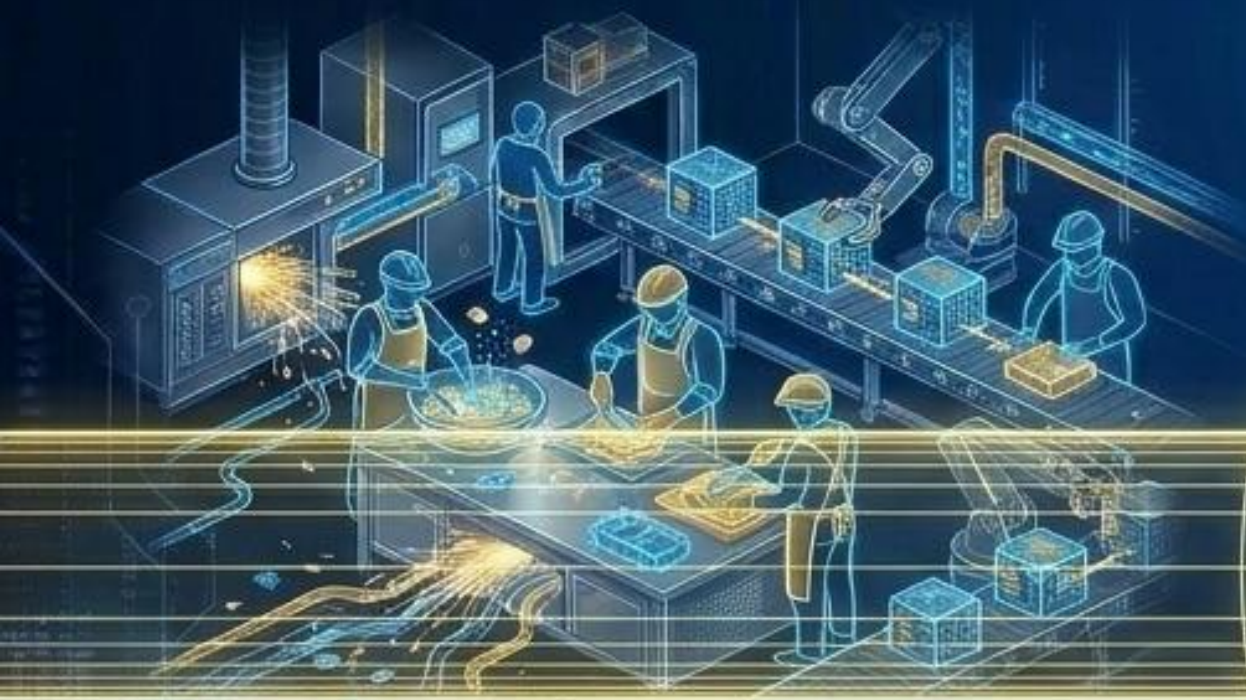
The Gatekeeper Toggle

Content must be explicitly designated for distribution by toggling "Include in app" to Yes. (Note: Datasets and Dataflows cannot be toggled).



The Protective Buffer

If January's report is published in the App, viewers will see exactly that static version. Developers can spend all of February breaking and rebuilding the report in the Workspace without disrupting the viewers' experience.



Messy "Workspace" Zone



Clean "App" Zone

App Distribution Architecture

Title
App name
Description
Support site
Contacts

Navigation ... New
> Reports
> Dashboards

Permission
☒ Entire organization
☐ Specific individuals or group
Search
☒ Allow users to connect...
☐ Allow users to make a copy...
☐ Allow users to share...

1

2

3

1. Setup & Identity

Define the App name, mandatory description, support URLs, and specific contacts for individual reports.

2. Navigation Architecture

Organize the user experience by building Sections (e.g., 'Reports' vs 'Dashboards'), adding external links, and intentionally hiding backend content.

3. Access Permissions

Assign the audience (either a restricted group or the entire organization).



Warning: Exercise extreme caution before granting 'Build' or 'Share' permissions, which allow viewers to copy reports or distribute underlying datasets.

Governance & Data Security



Integrated Data Protection

Data Sensitivity Labels are governed by the broader Microsoft 365 environment, not initiated natively within Power BI.

End-to-End Tracking

If enabled by IT, a sensitivity label applied to a .pbix file in the Desktop application will persist and be clearly reflected once the report is published into the Workspace Service.

The Pyramid of Trust



Tier 3: Certified Content (Peak)

The ultimate organizational standard. Controlled strictly by the Power BI Admin. Requires rigorous policy validation regarding data sourcing, ETL completeness, and absolute accuracy of DAX measures.

Tier 2: Promoted Content (Middle)

The creator vouches for the data. Admins, Members, and Contributors can promote reports or datasets—akin to signing their name to the work.

Tier 1: Standard Content (Base)

Raw workspaces. Origin and quality of data are unverified.

The Data Lifecycle Master Blueprint



1. Author

Build the .pbix file locally in Power BI Desktop.



2. Collaborate

Publish to a shared Workspace with strict Admin/Member access controls.



3. Distribute

Package finalized content into an App with curated navigation for read-only Viewers.



4. Govern

Apply M365 Sensitivity Labels and elevate trusted datasets through the Certification pipeline.